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Courtesy: UAE Presidential Court

UAE LEADERS DISCUSS NATIONAL ISSUES

President His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan yesterday received His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, at Qasr Al Bahr in Abu Dhabi. The leaders discussed various topics related to national affairs and the well-being of citizens. They also explored ways to further strengthen the UAE's progress and advance its ambitious national goals at both the local and international levels.

Biometric 'journey pass' to soon replace check-in, boarding pass

Credentials on phones are part of UN-backed plans to digitise air transport

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

The days of frantically searching for your boarding pass or running across an airport parking lot to make it in time for flight check-in may soon be a thing of the past. The UN body responsible for drafting airline policy — International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) — has proposed new guidelines to shake up existing rules for airports and airlines by introducing digital travel credentials or a 'journey pass'.

The pass would allow passengers to store vital travel information on devices. According to a *Times* report, the changes could come into effect in three years. The changes

The key feature of the ICAO DTC is that authorities can verify a digital representation of the passport data before the traveller's arrival and confirm the data's integrity and authenticity.

would make boarding passes and the need to check in for flights obsolete. Instead, flyers will download a "journey pass" to their phone when they book a flight. The pass will be automatically updated if any changes are made to the booking.

Biggest in aviation history

Amadeus' Director of Product Management, Valérie Viale, told the *Times* that the changes could be the biggest in the aviation industry in half a century. Her company has a system for processing passenger biometrics at each touchpoint and deleting all personal data within 15 seconds.

For at least the past few years, ICAO has been working on plans to digitise air transport, particularly through Digital Travel Credentials (DTCs). In December 2024, ICAO released a 'High-Level Guidance: Explaining the ICAO Digital Travel Credentials' document, indicating the concept and planning of DTCs. According to the report, the key feature of the ICAO DTC is that authorities can verify a digital representation of the passport data before the traveller's arrival and confirm the data's integrity and authenticity.

ICAO said the DTC could enable Enhanced screening capabilities (travel authorisation processing and pre-arrival screening) via the collection of accurate and trusted information, including facial biometrics, in advance of travel; support increasingly efficient border processes by expanding automated and biometrically-enabled processes and ensure faster and more convenient experiences for travellers.



SPORT

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Katy Perry gets free ride, but it isn't cheap for rest

Dh550,500 deposit for space travellers

DUBAI
BY MANJUSHA RADHAKRISHNAN
Entertainment Editor

Pop star Katy Perry made headlines on Monday as part of Blue Origin's first all-female space crew — the first of its kind in over 60 years.

According to reports, Blue Origin's New Shepard spacecraft can carry six passengers just past Earth's atmosphere, offering a few minutes of weightlessness and a stunning view of the

planet. While Blue Origin doesn't list an official price, interested travellers must submit a request and agree to a \$150,000 (Dh550,500) deposit. Other companies like Virgin Galactic charge \$450,000 (Dh1.65 million) per seat, while SpaceX's orbital flights have crossed the \$220 million (Dh807 million) mark.

Of course, fame flies free — celebrities like William Shatner and Michael Strahan reportedly paid nothing. Katy Perry likely joined that club too.

SEE ALSO P16

Hamas weighs Israel's 45-day truce proposal

MACRON TELLS NETANYAHU ORDEAL OF GAZA CIVILIANS 'MUST END'

GAZA

A senior Hamas official said yesterday the Palestinian Islamist movement expects to respond within 48 hours to an Israeli ceasefire proposal it received through mediators.

"Hamas will most likely send its response to the mediators within the next 48 hours, as the movement is still conducting in-depth consultations," the official told AFP.

Hamas said Monday it had received Israel's latest proposal to halt the war in Gaza, now in its 18th month.

The official said the offer includes a truce of at least 45 days in return for the release of 10 living hostages held in Gaza.

It also provides for the release of 1,231 Palestinian prisoners from Israeli jails and the entry of humanitarian aid into the territory, which has been under complete blockade since March 2.

Permanent end to war

The proposal calls for a "permanent end to the war" on the condition Palestinian factions in Gaza, including Hamas, disarm, the official said.

Hamas has rejected the disarmament demand as a "red line" and "non-negotiable".

Israel has yet to comment on the proposal's contents.

Of the 251 hostages seized

58

Israeli hostages are still held in Gaza, 24 of them alive

during the unprecedented October 2023 Hamas attack that sparked the war, 58 are still held in Gaza, including 34 the Israeli military says are dead.

Meanwhile, France's President Emmanuel Macron told Israel's leader during a phone call yesterday that the suffering of Gazan civilians "must end" and that only a ceasefire in Gaza could free remaining Israeli hostages.

"The ordeal the civilian populations of Gaza are going through must end," Macron posted on X after the call with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. He also called for "opening all humanitarian aid crossings" into the besieged Palestinian territory.

Netanyahu, who made a rare visit to Gaza yesterday, even as the military pressed on with its air and ground assault against the Palestinian territory, expressed to the French leader his "strong opposition to the establishment of a Palestinian state, stating that it would be a huge reward for terrorism".

— AFP

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